TechDella

PDF-04 · CHECKLIST

Email deliverability, *checked.*

SPF, DKIM, DMARC and the Gmail, Yahoo and Outlook sender rules, as a checklist you can work through with whoever manages your DNS.

FOR	TIME	YOU NEED
B2B teams sending newsletters, nurture and sales email	About 60 minutes, plus DNS changes	DNS access and admin access to each sending tool

START HERE

The rules in one page

If you send marketing email to Gmail, Yahoo or Outlook.com addresses, your domain needs SPF, DKIM and DMARC, one-click unsubscribe, and a low spam-complaint rate. Bulk senders that miss these see mail filtered to spam or rejected.

Treat the strictest column as the standard for every message you send: mailbox filters do not know which of your emails were "marketing".

REQUIREMENTS BY MAILBOX PROVIDER

Requirement	Gmail (Google)	Yahoo	Outlook.com (Microsoft)
Who counts as a bulk sender	Close to 5,000 or more messages to personal Gmail accounts in 24 hours. Once you qualify, you stay qualified.	Has bulk-sender requirements but publishes no volume threshold	More than 5,000 messages a day to Outlook.com, Hotmail.com and Live.com addresses
SPF	All senders: SPF or DKIM. Bulk: both	Required	Required (pass)
DKIM	Bulk: required	Required	Required (pass)
DMARC	Bulk: a DMARC record, policy can be `p=none`; From domain aligned with SPF or DKIM	Required, `p=none` minimum, aligned	Required, `p=none` minimum, aligned with SPF or DKIM
One-click unsubscribe	Bulk marketing mail: `List-Unsubscribe` + `List-Unsubscribe-Post` (RFC 8058); honor within 2 days	Required; honor within 2 days	Functional unsubscribe link expected
Spam-complaint rate	Keep below 0.3% in Postmaster Tools; Google advises staying under 0.10%	Keep below 0.3%	Not published as a number
Other	Valid forward and reverse DNS (PTR) for sending IPs; TLS; messages formatted to RFC 5322; do not impersonate Gmail From headers	Valid PTR; RFC 5322 format	Since May 5, 2025, non-compliant bulk mail is rejected with error `550 5.7.515`

WHAT THIS MEANS IN PRACTICE

Your email platform and your inbox provider (Google Workspace or Microsoft 365) both send as your domain. Each needs to be in SPF, sign with DKIM on your domain, and pass DMARC alignment. The usual culprit is a tool added later and never authenticated. List every sender in the sender inventory (page 6) before you touch DNS.

AUTHENTICATE

SPF and DKIM

SPF lists the servers allowed to send for your domain. DKIM signs each message so the receiver can check it was not changed and really came from you. You need both.

SPF checklist

- [ ] **Exactly one SPF record** on the domain (a TXT record starting `v=spf1`).
  Two SPF records make SPF fail with a permanent error (RFC 7208). Merge them into one.
- [ ] **Every sending service from your list is included**, using the include value from that service's own setup guide.
  Copy it from the vendor's documentation, not from a blog post: vendors change these values.
- [ ] **Ten DNS lookups or fewer.**
  Each `include`, `a`, `mx`, `ptr`, `exists` and `redirect` counts, including nested ones. Over ten and SPF returns an error (RFC 7208, section 4.6.4). Remove services you no longer use before you consider flattening.
- [ ] **The record ends in `~all` or `-all`**, never `+all`.
  `+all` authorizes the whole internet to send as you.
- [ ] **The Return-Path (envelope sender) of your marketing platform uses your domain** or a subdomain of it, so SPF can align with your From address.
  Many platforms call this a "custom return path" or "custom bounce domain".
- [ ] **Domains that never send email have a "null" SPF record**: `v=spf1 -all`.
  Pair it with a DMARC `p=reject` record so parked domains cannot be spoofed.

```
Example (replace with your vendors' values)
example.com.  TXT  "v=spf1 include:_spf.google.com include:[your-email-platform] ~all"
```

DKIM checklist

- [ ] **Each sending service signs with your domain** (`d=example.com` or a subdomain), not the vendor's shared domain.
  This is what lets DKIM align for DMARC. Check a received message: "Show original" in Gmail shows the `d=` value.
- [ ] **2048-bit keys** where the provider supports them.
  Google recommends 2048-bit DKIM keys in its Workspace setup guide.
- [ ] **One selector per service**, named so you can tell them apart (for example `google._domainkey`, `sb1._domainkey`).
  You can then rotate or revoke one service's key without touching the others.
- [ ] **A rotation date is on the calendar** for keys you manage yourself.
  Pick a cadence your team can keep (for example once a year) and write down who owns it.
- [ ] **Test after every change**: send to a Gmail and an Outlook.com address and confirm `spf=pass`, `dkim=pass` and `dmarc=pass` in the headers.

PROTECT

DMARC and BIMI

DMARC tells receivers what to do when a message claiming to be from your domain fails SPF and DKIM alignment, and sends you reports about who is sending as you. Start in monitoring mode, read the reports, then tighten.

DMARC checklist

- ☐ **A DMARC record exists** at `_dmarc.example.com`.
  The bulk-sender rules accept `p=none`, which only monitors.
- ☐ **Aggregate reports go to a mailbox or tool someone reads** (`rua=mailto:…`).
  Raw reports are XML. A DMARC reporting tool turns them into a list of sending sources.
- ☐ **Every legitimate source in the reports passes aligned SPF or DKIM.**
  Fix unknown or failing sources before you move past `p=none`.
- ☐ **Move to `p=quarantine`, then `p=reject`** once reports show only legitimate, passing mail.
  RFC 9989 (May 2026) removed the old `pct=` tag for partial rollout. Leave a few weeks between steps and keep reading the reports.
- ☐ **Subdomains are covered**, either by the parent policy or their own `sp=` / record.
  Attackers often spoof subdomains you forgot existed.

```
Stage 1, monitor:   _dmarc.example.com  TXT  "v=DMARC1; p=none; rua=mailto:dmarc@example.com"
Stage 2, quarantine: _dmarc.example.com  TXT  "v=DMARC1; p=quarantine;
rua=mailto:dmarc@example.com"
Stage 3, reject:     _dmarc.example.com  TXT  "v=DMARC1; p=reject; rua=mailto:dmarc@example.com"
```

BIMI (optional, after DMARC enforcement)

BIMI shows your logo next to messages in supporting inboxes. It is not a ranking factor for the inbox, but it does reward the work above.

- ☐ **DMARC is at enforcement**: `p=quarantine` or `p=reject`.
  BIMI does not work with `p=none`. Check the BIMI Group's current requirements for `pct`.
- ☐ **Your logo is an SVG in the SVG Tiny Portable/Secure (SVG Tiny PS) profile**, square, hosted over HTTPS.
- ☐ **You have decided whether you need a certificate.**
  Gmail shows BIMI logos only with a Verified Mark Certificate (VMC, needs a registered trademark) or a Common Mark Certificate (CMC). DigiCert issues a CMC if your logo has been used for at least 12 months on a domain you control (it can check Archive.org), or if it is similar to your registered trademark.
- ☐ **A BIMI TXT record** at `default._bimi.example.com` points to the SVG (`l=`) and certificate (`a=`).

SEND WELL

List, content and sending practice

Authentication proves who you are. Whether you reach the inbox after that depends mostly on whether people want your email: complaints, engagement and list quality.

List quality

- ☐ **Every contact opted in**, and you can show when and where.
  Store the form, page and timestamp with the contact.
- ☐ **Marketing consent is a separate, unticked checkbox** where the law requires it (for example the EU and UK).
- ☐ **No bought, rented or scraped lists.**
- ☐ **Hard bounces are suppressed automatically.**
- ☐ **A sunset rule** removes or re-permissions people who have not engaged in a set period you choose (for example 6 months).
  Apple Mail Privacy Protection inflates opens, so use clicks and replies as engagement signals too.
- ☐ **Cold outreach runs from a separate subdomain or domain**, never the domain your customers and newsletter rely on.

Sending practice

- ☐ **New domains and IPs are warmed up**: start with your most engaged contacts and raise volume gradually over several weeks.
  Your email platform's warm-up guide sets the exact schedule for its infrastructure.
- ☐ **Volume is steady.**
  Sudden spikes (a quarterly blast to everyone) look like spam behavior.
- ☐ **Marketing and transactional mail use different subdomains or streams**, so a bad campaign does not delay password resets or invoices.
- ☐ **The From name and address are consistent** and a real person can receive replies.
- ☐ **Unsubscribe is one click** and visible in the body as well as the header.

Monitoring

- ☐ **Google Postmaster Tools** is set up for your domain; someone checks the spam rate and compliance status weekly.
- ☐ **Microsoft SNDS** is set up if you send from dedicated IPs.
- ☐ **Your domain and sending IPs are not on major blocklists.**
  Check monthly and after any spike in bounces.
- ☐ **A weekly deliverability row** in your reporting: sent, delivered, bounce rate, complaint rate, click rate, unsubscribes.

WORKSHEET

Sender inventory

Everything that sends email as your domain, in one table. Fill it in before you change any DNS record, and keep it next to your DNS notes so the next tool you add gets authenticated on day one.

Sending service	What it sends	SPF include / IP	DKIM selector	Return-Path domain
Inbox (Google Workspace / Microsoft 365)	1:1 email			
Marketing email platform	Newsletters, nurture			
CRM / sales sequences				
Transactional (app, invoices)				
Support desk				
Calendar / scheduling tool				
Other:				
Other:				

BEFORE EVERY CAMPAIGN

Pre-send checklist

- [ ] Sent a test to Gmail and Outlook.com seed addresses; headers show SPF, DKIM and DMARC **pass**.
- [ ] The segment includes only opted-in, recently engaged contacts.
- [ ] Subject line matches the content; no misleading "Re:" or "Fwd:".
- [ ] Plain-text version included; images have alt text; the email reads fine with images off.
- [ ] Links point to your own domain (or a branded tracking domain), not URL shorteners.
- [ ] One-click unsubscribe header present; footer has the unsubscribe link and your postal address where law requires it.
- [ ] UTM parameters on every link, so replies and form fills are attributed to this send.
- [ ] Send time and volume are in line with your usual pattern.

Want us to check your *setup?*

We review authentication, list practice and nurture flows as part of our email marketing work, and we will tell you plainly what to fix first.

Request a growth audit

techdella.com/services/email-marketing/

Sources

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